

Why did we name our seminar series *Researchers & Roosters* ?

By María García Viguera, March 2024

There is a paradox that every researcher eventually encounters. The results that appear the simplest — an elegant figure, a clear explanation, an experiment that finally works — are often the ones that required the most time.

That is the spirit of this seminar series. We invite scientists, PhD students, and early-career researchers to share not only their results, but also the journey that made those results possible. In a way, we ask them to “paint a rooster.”

I like to begin these meetings with an old tale from ancient China.

It is said that in Imperial China, when the Year of the Rooster arrived, the emperor wanted to celebrate the occasion by commissioning the finest rooster painting ever created. He summoned the greatest painter in the Empire. Convinced that such talent would quickly produce a masterpiece, he waited for the painting with growing impatience.

The painter asked for six months. Then another six months. Then three more months.

After three years, the emperor went to her studio himself. There he found a large sheet of silk, still perfectly blank.

The painter quietly picked up her brush and, within a few moments, a rooster appeared on the silk. Every stroke was graceful, precise, and alive. The bird seemed ready to greet the dawn with its cry.

It was not simply a rooster: it was the rooster, the very essence of all roosters — past, present, and yet to come.

The emperor was deeply moved. He gazed at the painting for a long moment before turning to the painter.

Thank you, master painter, for this magnificent painting. But tell me... was it really necessary to make me wait for three long years?

The painter smiled and invited him to visit her home.



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There he discovered hundreds of sketches, notebooks filled with observations, studies of movement, books, brushes worn almost to nothing, and a garden full of roosters she had watched every morning.

Only then did he understand.

The painting had taken only a few minutes.

But learning to see that rooster had taken three years.



Perhaps that is what research is like.

What we present at the end often looks like a simple gesture: a few slides, an elegant explanation, an experiment that works.

But behind that gesture lie months — sometimes years — of curiosity, failed attempts, reading, conversations, and patient learning.

Today, each of our speakers comes to share the journey that made their rooster possible.

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and Marianne Costa.*